CLIMBING A ROPE (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Climbing or descending a rope is special movement. In 2024, climbing **doubles movement cost**, and the DM may call for a **Strength (Athletics)** check if the surface is **slippery** or has **few handholds**. The rope-specific DCs are **table rules**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Each foot climbed costs **double**: climbing pace is half your Speed (30 feet gives 15 feet per turn).
2. A **Climb Speed** removes this extra cost.
3. The DM asks for a **Strength (Athletics)** check. A Dexterity (Acrobatics) check remains possible in special cases. Table rule
4. Per the SRD: **DC 15** for a slippery surface or one with few handholds. Table: plain rope **DC 10**, knotted rope **DC 5**. Table rule
5. Factors raise or lower the DC (How to play page). Table rule

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⚠ What the SRD says:

- **Climbing**: every foot moved costs double movement (triple in Difficult Terrain).
- **Climb Speed**: it replaces Speed, with no extra cost.
- **DC 15**: at the DM's discretion, for a slippery surface or one with few handholds.

⚠ What is a table rule: Table rule

- The rope DCs (plain, knotted).
- The modifiers: weather, wet rope, gear, heavy armor.
- The climbing-time table.

⚠ Change from 2014

The cost is unchanged (each foot costs one more). The 2024 text adds a **DC 15** for a slippery surface or one with few handholds, where 2014 gave no DC.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

No DC for a rope, and nothing on the consequences of failure. Fix: the **DM announces before the game** the table DCs and what failure costs (no progress, a slip, a fall).

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the creaking rope, rough fibers burning the palms, and the void opening below.

CLIMBING A ROPE (5E, 2024 RULES) – HOW TO PLAY

Step 1 – Move along the rope:

Each foot climbed or descended costs **double** movement. With the **Dash** action, you gain extra movement equal to your Speed.

Example: Speed 30 ft, climbing 15 ft per turn. With Dash, 30 ft.

Step 2 – Choose the check:

The DM calls for a **Strength (Athletics)** check. They may allow Dexterity (Acrobatics) in a special situation. Table rule

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Step 3 – Set the DC: Table rule

Situation	DC
Knotted rope (many knots)	5
Plain rope, fair conditions	10
Slippery surface or few handholds (SRD)	15
Several unfavorable factors combined	15 or more

Step 4 – Adjust the DC: Table rule

- **Raise by +2 to +5**: wet or slippery rope, strong wind, rain, storm, frost, poor visibility, no gear.
- **Lower by 2 to 5**: climbing gear (harness, pitons, belay).
- **Advantage**: an ally uses the **Help** action to guide the climb or hold the rope.
- **Heavy armor**: the DM may impose Disadvantage.

Example: Brann (Athletics +5) climbs a knotted rope in the rain: DC 5 + 3 = 8. He rolls 12 + 5 = 17: success.

Step 5 – Count the time (Speed 30 ft): Table rule

Distance	Time needed
15 ft	1 turn
30 ft	2 turns
50 ft	4 turns
75 ft	5 turns

Common table questions.

Do I need a check to climb a rope?

Not always: climbing simply costs double movement. The DM may call for a Strength (Athletics) DC 15 check if the surface is slippery or has few handholds.

Is descending different from climbing?

No: climbing covers both, with the same costs and checks.

What about a Climb Speed?

You climb with no extra cost: you use your Climb Speed instead of Speed.

Can I climb faster?

Yes, with the **Dash** action: you gain extra movement equal to your Speed. With 30 ft, you climb 30 ft in the turn.

How long for 50 ft?

At 15 ft per turn, 4 turns (3.3 rounded up to the next turn). Table rule

Can an ally help?

Yes, with the **Help** action: it gives Advantage on your next ability check with the chosen skill (Athletics).

What happens on a failure?

The text doesn't say: the DM decides (no progress, a slip, a fall). A fall deals 1d6 bludgeoning damage per 10 feet. Table rule

Does heavy armor get in the way?

Not per the 2024 text. Disadvantage is possible, at the DM's discretion. Table rule

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

20 and 1 on a check

On an ability check, a 20 or a 1 has no special effect: no Critical Hit, no automatic failure.

Grappled and attacks

A Grappled creature can still attack: the condition only limits its movement.

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